
- RAG Learning

3.2 Conservatism

Politics — AQA (7152) — Paper 3 (Political Ideas)

Conservatism is the least systematic of the three core ideologies — by design. It begins from scepticism about the power of abstract reason to redesign society, which makes conservatives suspicious of the very kind of doctrine that liberalism and socialism supply. That is why Oakeshott described it as a *disposition* rather than a creed, and why the recurring exam question is whether conservatism is a coherent ideology at all.

Specification requirement. AQA names **five key thinkers** for conservatism. You must know their core ideas and be able to deploy them in 25-mark answers: **Thomas Hobbes, Edmund Burke, Michael Oakeshott, Ayn Rand** and **Robert Nozick**.

1. Core ideas

Human imperfection

The foundational conservative claim, and the sharpest break with liberalism and socialism. Human beings are imperfect in three distinct ways:

- **Psychologically** — driven by appetite and by a need for security and order; fearful of isolation and instability.
- **Morally** — capable of selfishness, cruelty and violence, which is why law, authority and punishment are necessary.
- **Intellectually** — reason is limited, and the social world is too complex to be understood fully, let alone redesigned. This is the premise that generates conservative caution about radical reform.

Tradition

Established customs and institutions embody **accumulated practical wisdom**: what has survived has been tested by generations of experience, which is more reliable than the reasoning of any single generation. Tradition also supplies continuity, stability and a sense of identity and belonging. Burke described society as a partnership between the living, the dead and those yet to be born — so the present generation are trustees, not owners, of their inheritance.

Organic society

Society is a living whole that has evolved, not a machine that can be dismantled and rebuilt. Its parts are interdependent, so changing one institution has unpredictable effects on others. It is naturally **hierarchical**, but hierarchy carries **obligation**: those with wealth and position owe a duty to those below them. Burke's "**little platoons**" — family, parish, locality, voluntary association — are where people acquire loyalty and moral habit.

Pragmatism

Judge policies by what works, not by conformity to doctrine. This is why conservative parties have accommodated themselves to the extension of the franchise, the welfare state and the market at different times without any sense of contradiction.

Change to conserve

Burke's principle: a state without the means of some change is without the means of its own conservation. Reform is the *condition* of preservation, not its opposite — but it should be gradual, growing out of existing practice rather than imposed from a blueprint.

2. Key thinkers

Thomas Hobbes (1588–1679) — *Leviathan* (1651)

- **Human nature** — needy, restless and competitive, pursuing security and advantage. Not evil, but dangerous in the absence of restraint.
- **The state of nature** — without a common power to keep all in awe, life would be one of continual fear and insecurity, with no industry, culture or society.

- **The social contract** — individuals rationally agree to surrender their freedom to an **absolute sovereign**, whose authority must be undivided if it is to be effective. Divided sovereignty invites civil war.

Exam Tip: Hobbes sits *awkwardly* in the conservative tradition, and saying so is a mark-scoring observation. He reasons from an abstract social contract and rational individualism — exactly the method Burke and Oakeshott reject. He is conservative in his conclusions (order precedes liberty) but arguably liberal in his premises.

Edmund Burke (1729–1797) — *Reflections on the Revolution in France* (1790)

- **Tradition and inheritance** — the intergenerational partnership; institutions carry wisdom their designers never articulated.
- **Anti-Jacobinism** — attacked the French revolutionaries for demolishing an entire social order in the name of abstract rights, predicting disorder and ultimately tyranny.
- **The American contrast** — Burke *supported* the American colonists. His test was not whether change occurred but whether it grew out of existing practice: the Americans defended established rights against Crown innovation, while the French destroyed an inheritance to build from theory.
- **Little platoons** — attachment to the small local community is the first link in the chain of public affection.
- **Empiricism** — policy should rest on evidence and experience, not on rationalist design.

Michael Oakeshott (1901–1990) — *On Being Conservative* (1956)

- **Anti-rationalism** — the belief that politics can be conducted from abstract theory is the characteristic modern error. Rationalists recognise only **technical knowledge** (which can be written as rules) and discard **practical knowledge** (acquired only through experience and apprenticeship) — precisely the wisdom that makes governing possible.
- **Politics as navigation** — he described political activity as sailing a boundless and bottomless sea, with no harbour and no appointed destination; the enterprise is to keep afloat on an even keel. There is no final destination to be reached by design.
- **The conservative disposition** — a preference for the familiar over the perfect, the tried over the untried, the actual over the possible.

Ayn Rand (1905–1982) — *Atlas Shrugged* (1957)

- **Objectivism** — reality is objective, reason is the only means of knowledge, and the individual is the highest value.
- **Rational and ethical egoism** — the pursuit of one's own rational self-interest is morally right; altruism treated as a *duty* is a denial of individual worth.
- **Anti-collectivism and anti-statism** — opposed to any subordination of the individual to the group or the state; strongly atomistic view of society.

Robert Nozick (1938–2002) — *Anarchy, State and Utopia* (1974)

- **Self-ownership** — individuals own themselves and therefore their talents and the fruits of their labour.
- **The minimal (night-watchman) state** — legitimate functions are limited to protection against force, theft and fraud, and enforcement of contracts. Anything more violates rights.
- **Entitlement theory** — a distribution is just if holdings were justly acquired and justly transferred, *regardless of the resulting pattern*. This is a direct attack on Rawls: redistributive taxation treats some people's talents as a resource for others.

3. Strands of conservatism

	Traditional	One Nation	New Right
Human nature	Imperfect; needs authority	Imperfect; needs obligation	Neo-lib: rational self-interested individual Neo-con: imperfect, needs moral authority
Society	Organic, hierarchical	Organic; "two nations" must be bridged	Neo-lib: atomistic Neo-con: needs restoring
State	Strong, paternalistic	Interventionist; accepts welfare	Minimal economically, strong socially

Economy	Property as the basis of order	Mixed economy; managed capitalism	Free markets, privatisation, deregulation
Associated with	Hobbes, Burke	Disraeli; post-war Conservatives	Rand, Nozick; Thatcher, Reagan

One Nation conservatism

Disraeli's warning about "**two nations**" of rich and poor held that a growing gulf between them threatened social cohesion and could provoke revolution. The response is paternalistic: welfare and intervention are justified by obligation, and by the prudential recognition that stability requires the poor to have a stake. This underpinned Conservative acceptance of the post-war welfare state.

The New Right

A fusion of two distinct strands:

- **Neo-liberalism** — free markets, privatisation, deregulation, lower direct taxation, control of inflation, restriction of trade union power. Welfare dependency is held to undermine self-reliance.
- **Neo-conservatism** — a strong state restoring order, authority and traditional morality; tough on law and order; assertive on national sovereignty and the traditional family.

Exam Tip: The **internal tension in the New Right** is examinable and frequently rewarded. It wants the state rolled back economically and strengthened socially. Critics argue these pull against each other: free markets are socially disruptive, dissolving the settled communities and traditional ways of life neo-conservatives wish to defend. Defenders reply that a free economy needs a strong framework of order and morality to function at all.

4. Tensions between the thinkers

The strongest 25-mark answers use the thinkers *against each other* rather than listing them.

Disagreement	One side	The other
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Basis of authority	Hobbes — a rational contract between individuals	Burke — inherited tradition and intergenerational partnership, which nobody chooses
Human nature	Burke, Oakeshott — imperfect, dependent, formed by social inheritance	Rand — the rational, self-creating individual is the highest value
Obligation to others	Traditional/One Nation — hierarchy carries duty; paternalism	Rand — altruism as duty denies individual worth
The economy	One Nation — mixed economy, welfare, managed capitalism	Neo-liberal — free markets; welfare erodes self-reliance
Method	Oakeshott — anti-rationalist; distrusts abstract theory	Rand, Nozick — reason from abstract first principles about rights

Exam Tip: The sharpest available point: **Rand and Nozick sit uneasily within conservatism.** They ground politics in abstract rational individualism — precisely what Burke and Oakeshott identify as the error that produced the French Revolution — and their programme would dismantle established institutions rather than conserve them. Whether the New Right is genuinely conservative is a live question, not a settled one.

5. Is conservatism a coherent ideology?

The charge: conservatism has no fixed principles, changes its position to suit circumstances, and functions as a defence of privilege dressed up as philosophy.

The reply: it rests on identifiable philosophical claims — human imperfection, the limits of reason, the organic nature of society, the value of accumulated experience — from which its scepticism about radical change follows logically. Pragmatism is a *consequence* of the epistemology, not the absence of one.

The strongest evidence for the charge is not pragmatism but the incompatibility between its strands: a tradition containing both Burke's inherited obligation and Rand's rational egoism is holding together positions that cannot both be true.

Key terms

Term	Definition
Human imperfection	The view that people are psychologically, morally and intellectually limited
Tradition	Inherited customs and institutions, valued as accumulated practical wisdom
Organic society	Society as an evolved, interdependent living whole rather than a designed construct
Paternalism	The duty of the privileged towards the less fortunate, arising from hierarchy
Noblesse oblige	The obligation of the wealthy and powerful to act for the benefit of others
Empiricism	Reliance on evidence and experience rather than abstract theory
Anti-permissiveness	Neo-conservative opposition to the loosening of moral and social norms
Atomism	The view of society as a collection of self-interested individuals (Rand, Nozick)
Libertarianism	Advocacy of maximum individual liberty and a minimal state